Soon after the great victory, the Bharatas consolidated their position by defeating a chieftain called Bheda on the Yamuna [27] . They were now the paramount power in the subcontinent with an empire that stretched from Punjab, across Haryana to the area around Delhi–Meerut. Their command over the cultural heartland probably gave the Bharatas influence that extended well outside the lands they directly controlled. It is possible that they consciously consolidated their position by encouraging the compilation of the Vedas. The Rig Veda is full of praise for the Bharata–Trtsu tribe, its chief Sudasa and the sage Vashishtha, suggesting that the book was put together under the patronage of the victorious tribe, probably over several generations following the great battle.

The real genius of the Bharatas, however, may lie in the fact that the Vedas do not confine themselves to the ideas of the victors but deliberately include those of sages from other tribes, including some of the defeated tribes. Thus, the hymns of the sage Vishwamitra, the great rival of Vashishtha, are given an important place in the compilation. In doing so, the Bharatas created a template of civilizational assimilation and accommodation rather than imposition. It was a powerful idea and would allow, over time, for people in faraway places like Bengal and Kerala to identify with this ancient Haryanvi tribe.

This is why the Bharatas remain alive in the name by which Indians have called their country since ancient times: ‘Bharat Varsha’ or the Land of the Bharatas. In time it would come to denote the whole subcontinent. Later texts such as the Puranas would define it as ‘The country that lies north of the seas and south of the snowy mountains is called Bharatam, there dwell the descendants of Bharata’. It remains the official name of India even today. Note that the name is also echoed outside India. In the Malay language, for instance, ‘Barat’ means West, signifying the direction from which Indian merchants came to South-East Asia.

Sudasa’s achievements may also have triggered an imperial dream that would remain embedded in the Indian consciousness. After his victories, Sudasa performed the Ashvamedha or horse sacrifice and was declared a Chakravartin or Universal Monarch. The word ‘chakravarti’ itself means